



AN ELM TREE at Seriina Covarrubias' house in Altadena survived the Eaton fire. So did two oaks, but they were cut down. MYUNG J. CHUN Los Angeles Times

SAVING A DEVASTATED TOWN'S LEAFY GRANDEUR

The oak trees saved the blue house on East Calaveras Street. Seriina Covarrubias was sure of it.

When she had returned after the Eaton fire, much of the Altadena neighborhood was in ruins. Homes and the nearby shops on North Fair Oaks had been destroyed. Her garage and her prized garden were demolished. Her house had been filled with smoke, but it survived, and so did the two massive oaks that sheltered it. She considered it a small miracle.

Weeks later, the Army Corps of Engineers had tagged the trees for removal, but certified arborists had inspected them as a second opinion and deemed them healthy. The oaks, believed to be at least 60 years old, didn't appear to obstruct any entrance points or pose a danger, and sported green leaves.

It didn't matter. On Feb. 23, nearly two months since the fire, they were cut down.

"When I found this out, it

The Eaton fire destroyed much of Altadena. Now residents fight to preserve the trees that survived.

BY COLLEEN SHALBY



A BLUE circle on a redwood signifies it's been deemed hazardous. But advocates added green tape to say it's healthy. JULIANA YAMADA Los Angeles Times

was just as bad as thinking that I had lost the house," said Covarrubias, 43. "I could have been there when they cut them down. I could have thanked them for the job that they did to protect my house."

By arborist Rebecca Latta's estimate, thousands of trees in Altadena have been tagged for removal: oaks, pines, sycamores, deodar cedars — trees that have canopied the town for decades.

Now, she and other arborists, landscape professionals and residents have banded together in an effort to save the trees believed to have survived the fire and preserve the leafy grandeur that once shaped the devastated town.

Officials have not released the number and types of trees that have been cut down. The Army Corps employs certified arborists to assess tree branches and root damage, and the likelihood of death within five years, according to the Coordinated Joint Information [See Trees, A5]

Palisades residents want to keep it exclusive

A proposal to build affordable housing on a burned gas station site is likely to meet strong opposition.

BY LIAM DILLON

On the ashes of his family's Shell gas station along Pacific Palisades' main commercial corridor, Justin Kohanoff envisions one of the grandest apartment buildings in the neighborhood's history. A Cape Cod-style white-brick facade with awnings and a metal roof. Eight stories tall. And as many as 100 apartments, including some reserved for low-income residents.

It was always in Kohanoff's long-term plans to redevelop the Sunset Boulevard gas station lot into housing. After the Palisades fire ripped through the community in January, long-term became now.

"It's gonna be beautiful," Kohanoff said. "I can't wait until it breaks ground and comes to fruition."

Kohanoff knows it won't happen without a fight.

Before the fire, the average home in Pacific Palisades cost \$3.5 million, the median household earned \$325,000 and the total number of rental units restricted as affordable housing was two. Some residents hope for even more exclusivity after the fires. One went so far as to propose in a community text message chain that a rebuilt Palisades should employ drones to track unfamiliar cars.

Kohanoff's project represents a wild reimagining of housing in the Palisades, where the apartment buildings that lined Sunset topped out at a few stories, and stood out of the way of the ocean views in hillside mansions towering above.

Although the devastation primarily affected the neighborhood's wealthy, single-family-home enclaves, the Palisades also lost more than 1,300 multifamily units and mobile homes in the di-

[See Palisades, A10]

A diminished Congress gets set for the president's address

BY MICHAEL WILNER AND FAITH E. PINHO

WASHINGTON — In his first address to a joint session of Congress, President Trump opened with an appeal for unity, a condemnation of hate and a call to resume the fight for civil

rights: "That torch is now in our hands," he told anxious lawmakers and a nation on edge.

That was eight years ago. This time, on Tuesday evening, Trump is expected to return to the House chamber with a less magnanimous message that asserts a more muscular presidency

wielding unparalleled executive power. "Tomorrow night will be big," the president wrote on social media. "I will tell it like it is!"

The address comes just six weeks into an administration that has shown greater command over the workings of federal bureau-

[See Trump, A7]

Tariffs to start for U.S. neighbors

BY ZEKE MILLER, JOSH BOAK AND ROB GILLIES

WASHINGTON — President Trump said Monday that 25% taxes on imports from Mexico and Canada would start Tuesday, sparking renewed fears of a North

American trade war that already showed signs of pushing up inflation and hindering growth.

"Tomorrow — tariffs 25% on Canada and 25% on Mexico. And that'll start," Trump told reporters in the White House's Roosevelt Room. "They're going to have to have a tariff."

Trump has said the tariffs are to force the two U.S. neighbors to step up their fight against fentanyl trafficking and stop illegal immigration. But Trump has also indicated that he wants to even the trade imbalance with both countries and push more factories to re-

[See Tariffs, A10]

An Indigenous push at UC

Native Americans call for scholars to prove their heritage after some claims are reversed. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Lakers' position in the West key

Team's rise in conference standings could mean deep playoff run, Dylan Hernández writes. **SPORTS, B10**

Oscar winner's plea for cinemas

Why "Anora" writer-director Sean Baker's "battle cry" for movie-going may fall on deaf ears. **BUSINESS, A6**

Weather

Cool, mostly sunny. L.A. Basin: 64/50. **B6**

For the latest news, go to **latimes.com**.

Printed with soy inks on partially recycled paper.



U.S. MARINES are deployed along the border with Mexico near the San Ysidro crossing in February. DENIS POROY Associated Press

Mexico asylum bids soar in the Trump era

BY KATE LINTHICUM

NAUCALPAN DE JUÁREZ, Mexico — It wasn't long ago that record numbers of migrants were claiming asylum at the U.S. southern border, overwhelming federal agents and backlogging the immigration courts.

Now the border is the quietest it's been in years, largely because the Trump administration has stopped processing asylum claims there — and pushed that responsibility farther south.

Mexico has seen more asylum applications over the last several weeks than at any time in recent mem-

[See Mexico, A7]



The day's top stories, at your fingertips.

Scan the code to download the app.

